

Episode 89: Once Upon a Time... (53) – The Story of Creating Colours That Convince Viewers with a Limited Number of Available Colours

The world is in Golden Week. I myself am actually in Italy. My fifth visit to Italy in five years, and I'm immediately hit with heavy rain day and night... Hmm, someone's conspiracy?

While I'm in Italy, the Tokyo production sites are working through Golden Week. Unable to finish scheduled work before departure, I'm travelling through Italy with a laptop and pen tablet. Connecting to the internet through hotel lines, I'm exchanging and checking setting data with Tokyo. While the world has become convenient, work chases you wherever you go (laughs).

And as generally expected, I couldn't finish this series manuscript in time either, so I'm currently writing at my hotel (sweat). Moreover, with the 7-hour time difference, whether I can make the update deadline... Ah, sorry...

Now then.

Finally the new paint problem was settled. Coo's basic body colour was also decided. Work on character colour samples progressed using the new colours that arrived.

Coo... His carefully considered body colour was cleared with new colours.

Yosuke and Tetsuro... This father-son pair was decided relatively smoothly. They're alike, after all. Simple clothing too. I was careful with skin colour - the balance of tanning. Which colour (which paint) to use to express "tanned East Asian" feel was key. If too dark, the balance with hair would be bad, and differentiation from Polynesians would be difficult. So it became relatively bright. Naturally, the child got a darker tan to look more energetic.

Tony... With the atmosphere of "Australian guy," I made him white-skinned with slightly pinkish skin colour. However, I decided not to tan him much.

Cathy... Her carefully considered skin colour was also cleared with new colours. However, to "still make her skin look bright and feminine," I made her shirt blackish so her skin would look brighter by contrast. The "rain shower scene" had the perfect balance between underwear and skin (laughs).

Among her belongings a camera bag appears, and wanting it to look like professional photographer equipment, I made it a yellow and black NIKON bag instead of a regular duralumin bag.

Blue and White Tip... These two dolphins were quite challenging. "White Tip" was easy - white spots made it immediately recognisable - but why "Blue" was blue meant it was probably more bluish than other dolphins. But how blue is blue? After various trials, I landed on "ah, this is probably fine." Ultimately, "don't overthink it" (burst).

Also, the dolphin body upper/lower surface colour division problem. Real dolphins don't have sharply divided colours - the boundary lines are gradated - but animation can't easily do that, so the balance was difficult. But ultimately, rather than aiming for something too subtle, it would be better to be clear within the presentation, so that's how the colours turned out.

That was roughly how the main appearing characters went.

While deciding colours this way, a new issue arose among everyone: "Should character brightness and appearance be the same for outdoor and indoor scenes?"

For outdoor scenes, if the sun is shining brightly, you can create a strong sunlight impression by making shadow areas smaller and shadows slightly darker, and even if not so sunny, normally coloured with regular shadow artwork would probably be okay.

But what about indoors? "Probably a bit darker, right?" However, "would simply making everything slightly darker really work?"

Outdoors, strong tropical sunlight pours down. But indoors, even in tropical simple buildings, they're not hermetically sealed spaces with complete light blocking - windows and doors everywhere with outside brightness constantly entering.

Nizo-san's interior art boards were drawn relatively soft and bright. While outdoors were blindingly bright, interiors might be shadowy, but they had the softness of brightness your eyes adjust to indoors.

"How about adding highlights along character outlines in the artwork?" Such a proposal was made. Not highlights that strongly suggest light reflection with sharp clarity, but soft colour differences not much different from normal parts.

Okura-san submitted character settings with added highlight artwork, and I made several colour sample patterns based on those.

First, the basic "normal" colour direction sample with highlights slightly brighter than "normal" colour. This became too bright. Depending on how you looked at it, it could appear brighter than outdoor cases.

Next, making the basic colours one shade darker overall with shadow colouring, and painting highlights with "normal" colours. This was subtly good as expected. The bottleneck was paint variations.

With today's digital tools, you could easily do "lower brightness by X%..." with a few clicks in Photoshop, but in those cel paint days, to make colours one shade darker meant "painting with paint that looks darker." The paint variations we had made things too dark, causing characters to float (or sink) against backgrounds.

Hmm...

After much consideration, I created a "partially darken colours to utilise highlights" approach. For example, leave hair and skin at basic "normal colour" without darkening, and add soft highlights. Only bright coloured parts like shirts get one shade darker colours, with highlight areas painted in that part's original "normal colour" - a "hybrid method" in today's terms.

Looking at character balance when lined up, I carefully decided colours person by person using available paints. This balanced nicely on screen.

With today's digital colouring, you can really easily modify and adjust colour tones and brightness, so you can create things to some extent without much thinking, but looking back, in those days we really used our heads to squeeze out solutions.

Not just cases like "making things slightly darker," but in every situation - depicting image space scenes, realistic depictions like flame reflections - we constantly faced "ah, we don't have paint colours between this colour and that colour..."

Each time, we'd rack our brains, try countless combinations of available paints, and create convincing combinations to get through.

While today certainly has today's struggles and considerations, "devising ways to create convincing colours for viewers with limited available colours" wasn't just my battle - it was the fight of all colour direction staff in the anime industry at that time.

(09.05.01)